shamefully oppressed by Houssein Khan's people. It formerly belonged to Houssein Khan, ambassador to England.[65]

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, April 6, 1844*

Perhaps you may have seen in the English papers something about the doings of a certain chief called Shahmeel, this man is the chief or king for he now calls himself Shahmeel Shah of a tribe of people called Lezgies who inhabit the mountains which have been called the eastern spur of the Caucasus.[66] They are Mahomedans of the Soonee[67] sect but they are by far the most liberal of any of the four divisions of that sect. Altho the whole of Georgia has been overrun by the Russians these people and the Circassians have never been conquered. And the Russians have had almost constant hostilities with them. Latterly this Shahmeel has come into power and has put some order amongst them and last year his armies beat the Russians in several battles. Georgia is one of the penal settlements of Russia and many of the troops who are there are sent there as a punishment, no troops in the world are so miserably fed, paid and clothed as the Russians, and before the Persians sent back Russian deserters they had always two battalions of these men in the service. Now instead of deserting to Persia they desert to Shahmeel and he has several regiments of these men in his service; they are in great measure composed of Poles and other foreigners but many are true Russians. These men are well paid clothed and fed and of course they fight well because they fight with ropes about their necks. In fact such power has this Shahmeel Shah now obtained that it is said this year the Russians intend to send an expedition of above one hundred thousand men against him (some say 200,000), but I should think they would not be able to send even the first named number; a little assistance now from Persia or perhaps even from Turkey might drive the Russians once more over the Caucasus.

You may recollect that last autumn I gave you an account of the slaughter of the Armenian (American I read it by mistake) by the Turks of Constantinople, you will perhaps have seen from the papers ere this reaches you that the British and French Ambassadors are endeavouring to force the Turkish government

[65] Hussein Khan was Mohammed Shah's special envoy to England in 1839, during the Shah's vain attempt to have the British ambassador, Sir John McNeill, recalled. The Persian had to make so many concessions to Lord Palmerston, without attaining the object of his mission, that on his return to Persia he "ate many sticks," i.e., was severely bastinadoed.

[66] For an account of the career of Shāmil, cf. *Encyclopaedia of Islam,* vol. 4, pt. 1, p. 306–7, and bibliography. See also footnote 38.

[67] The two chief sects of Islam are the Sunni and Shi'a. The Persians are of the latter sect, the Turks the former. For an account of the essential differences between the two, cf. e.g., Encyclopaedia of Islam, vol. 4, pt. 1, p. 350–58, with bibliography.

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